

חג השבועות

SHIUR NOTES ♦ RABBI SHALOM ROSNER

Chag HaShavuos

A shiur by Rabbi Shalom Rosner ♦ Na'aseh VeNishma

Shavuos is the day without a date. The Torah gives no explicit calendar entry for Matan Torah — the moment the world changed forever. Yet the Talmud is clear: it happened on the sixth of Sivan, and it happened not just once. It happens every year. Every person who opens a sefer on Shavuos night, every child who repeats the words of the Aseres HaDibros, stands at Sinai. That is the premise of this shiur: the claim that Matan Torah was not a moment in the past, but a permanent door, and we are always only a step away from walking through it.

THEME 1

The Holiday Without a Date

וְלֹא נִקְבַּע לוֹ זְמַן –
כִּי אֵין קֶץ לַמַּתָּן וּמִסְפָּר לַלְמִידָה.

“And no time was fixed for it — because there is no limit to the giving, and no count to the learning.”

Ba'al HaTurim on the absence of a date for Matan Torah

Every Yom Tov in the Torah has an explicit date in the pasuk. *B'asarah lachodesh ha'rishon* — Pesach. *Bachodesh hashevi'i* — Sukkos. But Shavuos? The Torah counts forty-nine days and says: *the day after, the fiftieth*. No date. No month. Only the distance from Pesach.

The Ba'al HaTurim finds in this absence a message: the giving of Torah is not a fixed event. It is an eternal process. Every moment of genuine Torah learning is a moment of Matan Torah. Every *chidush* — original insight — is a flame lit at Sinai. The holiday has no date because its content refuses to be contained in time. This is why we stay up all night on Shavuos. Not simply to learn Torah — we learn Torah every night. We stay up because we are *re-enacting the vigil at the foot of the mountain*. We do not commemorate Matan Torah. We live it.

“Every day that you open a sefer, you are at Sinai. The mountain did not close when Moshe descended. It is still there, and the Torah is still being given — to anyone who is willing to receive it.”

Shiur notes prepared by Matthew Miller ♦ TheOtherMatthewMiller.com

These notes are a study aid, not a verbatim transcript.

THEME 2

Na'aseh VeNishma — The Unprecedented Answer

נַעֲשֶׂה וְנִשְׁמָע

“We will do, and we will hear.”

Shemot 24:7

The rational order is: first hear, then do. *Nishma* — understand the terms — and *then naase* — commit. Bnei Yisrael reversed this sequence. *Na'aseh venishma*. We will do — and afterward we will understand.

The Gemara in Shabbos (88a) records that the ministering angels came down and tied two crowns onto every Jew at that moment: one for *na'aseh*, one for *venishma*. They had done what no created being had done before. They had said *yes* before they heard the question.

Reb Bunim of Peshischa explains: the clarity of the moment at Sinai was so complete, so overwhelming, that any other response would have been impossible. The people *saw* that Torah was life. When you truly see that fire is hot, you do not need to reason about whether to pull your hand away. *Na'aseh* was not blind faith — it was perfect clarity.

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THEME 3

K'Ish Echad B'Lev Echad — Unity from Vision

כְּאִישׁ אֶחָד בְּלֵב אֶחָד

“As one man with one heart.”

Rashi on Shemot 19:2

The pasuk says Bnei Yisrael camped at the foot of Har Sinai. The verb is *vayichan* — singular. They camped as one. Rashi captures it: *k'ish echad b'lev echad* — as one man, with one heart.

Rav Meir Shapiro, founder of the Daf Yomi, distinguishes between two kinds of *achdus*. The first is the unity of necessity — you are on a sinking ship and you must work together or drown. This is *achdus mitzarah*, unity from crisis. It is real, but it is temporary. Once the crisis passes, people drift apart.

The second is *achdus mitvoch chazon meshutaf* — unity from shared vision. This is what happened at Sinai. Every Jew — from Moshe at the summit to the children at the foot of the mountain — saw the same thing. The same fire. The same thunder. The same light that was the primordial Torah. And from that shared vision, a unity was born that no argument, no exile, no generation-gap could permanently destroy. This is the unity Shavuot asks us to restore each year.

“There are two kinds of Achdus: unity born of necessity — like animals on Noach’s Teiva — and unity born of a shared dream. Matan Torah was the second kind. Unprecedented before and since. And we are the descendants of that moment.”

THEME 4

Ruth and the Willing Convert

כִּי אֶל-אֲשֶׁר תֵּלְכִי אֵלָּה,
וּבְאֲשֶׁר תָּלִינִי אָלָיו.
עַמִּי עָמִי וְאֱלֹהֵיךָ אֱלֹהֵי.

“Where you go, I will go; where you lodge, I will lodge; your people are my people and your God is my God.”

Rus 1:16

Why do we read Megilas Rus on Shavuot? One answer: Rus accepted the Torah the way Bnei Yisrael accepted it at Sinai — with complete, unconditional commitment. She did not ask for a list of the *mitzvos* she was taking on. She did not negotiate terms. She said: *your people, my people. Your God, my God.* And then she walked.

This is *na'aseh venishma* in miniature. The unconditional *yes*.

But there is a second, deeper connection. The Midrash notes that Rus was a Moabite princess. She had every worldly reason to stay in Moav — family, status, comfort. She chose *less* of the world in order to have more of what matters. And from that choice came the entire Davidic line, culminating in Moshiach. The Torah was received in the wilderness — by people who had nothing. Rus received it by choosing to have nothing. In both cases, the empty hands were the ones that could hold the most.

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THEME 5

The Night of Shavuos — Why We Stay Awake

ליל שְׁמוֹרִים – תְּקוּן לַיִל שָׁבוּעוֹת.

“A night of vigil — the Tikkun of Shavuos night.”

Zohar, Parshas Emor

The Zohar teaches that on Shavuos night, the gates of heaven open at midnight. Those who learn Torah through the night become, in a mystical sense, attendants at the chuppah — the wedding canopy between Hashem and Bnei Yisrael. For Shavuos is Yom HaChuppah, the day of the giving — and every giving is a marriage.

Rav Yosef Karo, the Beis Yosef, had a dream on Shavuos night in which the Maggid — a heavenly voice — told him: *Had you not fallen asleep, I would have revealed deeper secrets of Torah.* He was mortified. He never slept again on Shavuos night. From that story the custom of *Tikkun Leil Shavuos* — learning through the entire night — spread across the Jewish world.

The practical lesson Rabbi Rosner draws: the gate is open on Shavuos night. We do not know what *sod* — what secret — is waiting on the other side. The cost of staying awake is tiredness. The cost of sleeping is immeasurable. The gate is open. Walk through.

“Every night of Shavuos is Leil Shimurim — a night that is guarded, set apart. The angels stand closer. The Torah is more accessible. You will never know what you would have learned had you stayed awake — and that is precisely the point.”

The Sinaitic Covenant — Then and Now

אֲנֹכִי ה' אֱלֹהֶיךָ
אֲשֶׁר הוֹצֵאתִיךָ מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם.

“I am Hashem your God who brought you out of the Land of Egypt.”

Shemot 20:2 — The First of the Aseres HaDibros

The first of the Ten Commandments is not a commandment. It is an *anochi* — an *I am*. A self-introduction. Hashem does not begin the Torah with a law; He begins with a relationship. *I am your God. I am the one who redeemed you.*

This sequence is the foundation of the entire covenant. First: redemption. Then: relationship. Then: obligation. We do not keep Torah because we are afraid of Hashem. We keep Torah because Hashem first carried us out of Egypt on eagles' wings and said: *I want you*. The *mitzvos* are not a burden imposed on strangers — they are the language of an ongoing love story.

Rabbi Rosner connects this to Shavuot: we do not simply *receive* the Torah tonight. We *renew the covenant*. Every year, Shavuot is a *chuppa*. Every year, we say *na'aseh venishma* again. Not because we forgot — but because love, like Torah, is not a one-time event. It is a daily choice.

נַעֲשֶׂה וְנִשְׁמָע

“We will do, and we will hear.”

Shemot 24:7 — The eternal response at Sinai

Shavuot is not the holiday of the past. It is the holiday of the eternal present. The mountain is still there. The fire is still burning. The Torah is still being given — to anyone who comes to receive it with openness, with *na’aseh venishma*, with the certainty that what they are receiving is not a set of laws but a way of being alive.

The clarity that made *na’aseh venishma* possible — that clarity is available to us too. Not through thunder or lightning, but through learning, through *tefillah*, through the quiet voice of a teacher. Sinai is everywhere that Torah is taken seriously. May we all find ourselves, this Shavuot, at the foot of the mountain.

About these notes. These shiur notes were prepared by Matthew Miller from the audio and video recording of Rabbi Shalom Rosner’s shiur on Chag HaShavuot. They are a study aid intended to preserve and share the teachings — not a verbatim transcript. The shiur was recorded and produced as part of an ongoing media collaboration.
